

MARRIAGE STORY

Written and Directed by Noah Baumbach

Black.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
What I love about Nicole...

INT. THEATER. MANHATTAN. DAY

Nicole, early 30's, appears out of the dark.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
She makes people feel comfortable
about even embarrassing things.

We remain CLOSE on her face in shadow. She's very still
and very serious.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
She really listens when someone is
talking...

EXT. FLATBUSH AVENUE, PARK SLOPE, BROOKLYN. DAY

Her coming out of a subway. A young "funny" ASPCA
solicitor stops her.

SOLICITOR
Hey, you look like you care about
animals?

NICOLE
I do.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
...sometimes she listens TOO
much, for too long-- She's
a good citizen.

The kid launches into his pitch. She listens intently and
starts writing down her phone number.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
She always knows the right thing
to do when it comes to difficult
family shit.

INT. CHARLIE AND NICOLE'S APARTMENT. DAY

Charlie is sulking. A hand holds out a phone.

NICOLE (O.S.)
Just call him.

CHARLIE
No.

NICOLE (O.S.)
Call him.

CHARLIE
No.

NICOLE
(with real empathy)
Call him.

He reluctantly grabs the phone.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
I get stuck in my ways and she
knows when to push me and when to
leave me alone.

INT. CHARLIE AND NICOLE'S APARTMENT. ANOTHER DAY

She cuts their son, (8 years old) Henry's hair. We see
Charlie sweeping up.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
She cuts all our hair.

Cuts Charlie's hair. We see the kid sweeping up.

Cuts her own in the mirror. Charlie and the kid play in
the background.

She sweeps up her own hair.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
She's always inexplicably brewing
a cup of tea that she doesn't
drink.

INT. CHARLIE AND NICOLE'S APARTMENT. SEVERAL DAYS

A kettle whistles.

STILL LIFES of mugs of tea on window sills, bookshelves,
Henry's toy shelf, on the floor...

All the kitchen cabinets are open. Charlie closing
drawers, picking up shoes. Charlie hitting his head on the
corner of an open cabinet.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
And it's not easy for her to put
away a sock, or close a cabinet,
or do a dish, but she tries for
me.

A framed PHOTO of Nicole, Sandra (her mom) and Cassie (her
sister) standing in the front lawn of a Hollywood home.
Nicole is pretending to step on the reclining dog.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
 Nicole grew up in LA around actors
 and directors and movies and TV
 and is very close to her mother,
 Sandra, and, Cassie, her sister.

INT. CHARLIE AND NICOLE'S APARTMENT. ANOTHER DAY

Charlie rips open a present. It's a trumpet.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
 Nicole gives great presents. She
 is a mother who plays -- really
 plays -- she never steps off
 playing or says it's too much (and
 it must be too much some of the
 time).

EXT. PROSPECT PARK, BROOKLYN. DAY

She and Henry play in the park with Star Wars figures. The
 kid makes high pitched sounds for the fights.

HENRY
 Arrrh, waaa, urgh...

NICOLE
 Arrgh--

HENRY
 No, he's dead.

NICOLE
 My guy is dead?

HENRY
 He's dead but you can use this
 guy.

NICOLE
 (taking that guy)
 Arrrhggg--

CHARLIE (V.O.)
 She's competitive.

INT. CHARLIE AND NICOLE'S APARTMENT. ANOTHER DAY

Nicole, Charlie and Henry are playing Monopoly.

NICOLE
 Goddammit! I was just IN jail!

Henry and Charlie look at each other and laugh.

NICOLE
 Do NOT laugh at me. I'm serious.
 Do NOT LAUGH AT ME!

INT. HENRY'S ROOM. ANOTHER NIGHT

Nicole is reading to Henry in bed. She's falling asleep while reading, but still managing to read.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
She's a great dancer. Infectious.
She makes me wish I could dance.

INT. THEATER. NIGHT

Nicole putting on a song and getting people to dance at a cast party.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
She always says when she doesn't know something or hasn't read a book or seen a film or a play (whereas I fake it or say something like, "I haven't seen it in a while.") She keeps the fridge over-full. No one is ever hungry in our house. She can drive a stick.

INT. CHARLIE AND NICOLE'S KITCHEN. ANOTHER DAY

Charlie's trying to open a jar of pickles. He struggles. He knocks it on a table. Grabs a dish towel and tries it that way. No luck.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
She's amazing at opening jars because of her strong arms, which I've always found very sexy.

INT. CHARLIE AND NICOLE'S APARTMENT. ANOTHER DAY

On TV, a younger Nicole (acting in a movie) is part of a raucous college party.

NICOLE IN THE MOVIE
You might as well get what you paid for!

She grabs her shirt and lifts it-- We PAUSE mid-lift before it comes off.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
She's brave. After that movie, All Over The Girl, she could have stayed in LA and been a movie star, but she gave that up to do theater with me in New York.

INT. THEATER. DAY

We're back to the first image of her face in half-shadow. Suddenly she walks forward and into a spotlight.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
My crazy ideas are her favorite
things to figure out how to
execute.

She walks across the floor and climbs (scales like a rock-face) the body of a male actor.

CHARLIE (O.S.)
Try it crawling but also standing.

We see that she's on a stage, rehearsing for a play.

CHARLIE (V.O.)
She's my favorite actress.

INT. THEATER. SAME DAY

CLOSE on Charlie, early 30's, in deep thought. A warm yellow glow on his face.

NICOLE (V.O.)
What I love about Charlie...
Charlie is undaunted. He never
lets other people's opinions or
any set-backs keep him from what
he wants to do.

INT. PIZZERIA, PARK SLOPE, BROOKLYN. DAY

Charlie eats sloppily with Henry at a pizza place. He suddenly stands up and walks around to Henry's side. He asks Henry to raise his arms. He lifts Henry's sweater up over his arms and turns it around to face the right way.

NICOLE (V.O.)
Charlie eats like he's trying to
get it over with and like there
won't be enough food for everyone.
A sandwich is to be strangled
while devoured. But he's
incredibly neat and I rely on him
to keep things in order.

INT. CHARLIE AND NICOLE'S APARTMENT. LATE DAY

Nicole is reading in a room. All the lights go out. She looks up. Charlie is at the switch.

CHARLIE

Sorry.

NICOLE (V.O.)

He's energy conscious.

He turns them back on.

NICOLE (V.O.)

He doesn't look in the mirror too often. He cries easily in movies.

EXT. MOVIE THEATER. DAY

He and Henry exit a movie theater. Both of them are crying.

HENRY

I cried four times.

CHARLIE

Me too. I wonder if it was the same four.

NICOLE (V.O.)

He is very self-sufficient -- he can darn a sock and cook himself dinner and iron a shirt.

INT. CHARLIE AND NICOLE'S KITCHEN. EVE

He's cooking - it's elaborate. There are a lot of pots, a lot of steam. Henry is "helping."

HENRY

(holding up a knife)
The peppers are cut!

NICOLE (V.O.)

He rarely gets defeated (which I feel like I always do).

INT. CHARLIE AND NICOLE'S APARTMENT. ANOTHER DAY

Nicole is raging about something.

NICOLE (V.O.)

Charlie takes all of my moods steadily, he doesn't give in to them or make me feel bad about them. He's a great dresser, he never looks embarrassing which is hard for a man.